

Apparent Feminism as a Methodology for Technical Communication and Rhetoric

Journal of Business and Technical
Communication

2016, Vol. 30(1) 3-28

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DOI: 10.1177/1050651915602295

jbtcc.sagepub.com



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Abstract

This article introduces apparent feminism, which is a new approach urgently required by modern technical rhetorics. Apparent feminism provides a new kind of response that addresses current political trends that render misogyny unapparent, the ubiquity of uncritically negative responses to the term *feminism*, and a decline in centralized feminist work in technical communication. More specifically, it suggests that the manifestation of these trends in technical spheres requires intervention into notions of objectivity and the regimes of truth they support. Apparent feminism is a methodology that seeks to recognize and make apparent the urgent and sometimes hidden exigencies for feminist critique of contemporary politics and technical rhetorics. It encourages a response to social justice exigencies, invites participation from allies who do not explicitly identify as feminist but do work that complements feminist goals, and makes apparent the ways in which efficient work actually depends on the existence and input of diverse audiences.

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Keywords

feminism, technical rhetorics, objectivity, social justice, efficiency

Contemporary public discourse about reproduction—just one of several possible examples of contemporary public discourse about feminist concerns—provides an urgent need for work at the intersections of feminisms and technical communication. Visible rhetorics,¹ medical rhetorics, and rhetorics of science and technology, in particular, have recently been utilized in service of radical legislation that points to a serious need for feminist perspectives on legal technical communication occurring in the public sector. For example, several states have recently passed or proposed legislation requiring people seeking abortions to undergo various medically extraneous procedures; in February 2012, Texas senator Dan Patrick (R-Houston) won the support of a district judge, allowing a new law (formerly HB 15) to amend the 2003 Woman's Right to Know Act (also known as Chapter 171 of the Texas Health and Safety Code) so that people² seeking abortions must have an ultrasound, hear the doctor describe the "child," see a sonogram or listen to a heartbeat, and then wait 24 hours before beginning the procedure (Arizona Women's Health and Safety Act, 2012; Eckholm & Severson, 2012; Jones, 2012; SB 484, 2012; Woman's Right to Know Act, 2012). Feminist responses to such laws were swift; Lithwick (2012), for example, wrote that a similar law requires "that women seeking an abortion in Virginia will be forcibly penetrated [by being required to have a transvaginal ultrasound] for no medical reason . . . [which] would constitute rape under the federal definition" (¶1). As it often does, backlash to this feminist outcry asserted a deep and malicious feminist bias.

This situation leaves me, a feminist social justice activist and technical communicator, with a series of questions: How might feminist technical communicators persuasively point out the bias inherent in all worldviews, even those that people often perceive as neutral? How might they intervene in unjust situations, particularly in technical contexts in which objectivity is highly valued? And how might they best decide which situations are most deserving of this sort of attention? This article introduces an apparent feminist methodology that highlights the urgency of responding to such contemporary, oppressive situations. Technical communication scholars and practitioners need an apparent feminist methodology in order to intervene in situations in which technical documentation unfairly and uncritically engages in oppression while feigning objectivity.

To bolster the continued importance and success of technical communication as a discipline, we must pay attention to the powerful ways that critical and cultural scholarship such as apparent feminism can help us to reshape our world and the ways we move through it. For example, the aforementioned legislation evidences that female bodies are under attack, and an apparent feminist methodology can point to methods by which technical communicators can intervene. For example, countersuits to laws that restrict abortion access have been filed in a number of states. In addition, apparent feminism can be used to leverage new understandings of gendered relations in business, education, and social structures.

Apparent feminism is a methodology that seeks to recognize and make apparent the urgent and sometimes hidden exigencies for feminist critique of contemporary technical rhetorics. It encourages a response to social justice exigencies, invites participation from allies who do not explicitly identify as feminist but do work that complements feminist goals, and makes apparent the ways in which efficient work actually depends on the existence and input of diverse audiences. Thus, this methodology recognizes a diversity of credible (and biased) perspectives while valuing embodiment and interrogating the way that bodies—especially female bodies—are represented. An apparent feminist methodology is necessary because of (a) current political trends that render misogyny unapparent at the nexus of social, ethical, political, and practical technical communication domains (Hart-Davidson, 2001; Johnson, 1998; Miller, 1989); (b) the ubiquity and globalized, networked distribution of uncritically negative responses to the term *feminism*³; and (c) a decline in centralized feminist work in technical communication over the past 15 years.

First, I provide a history of the feminist technical communication research most relevant to this project. Second, I discuss the interdisciplinary scholar-activists whose work apparent feminism builds on (Bray, 1997; Halberstam, 2002, 2005; hooks, 1989, 1994, 1995, 2004; LaDuke, 1999, 2005). Third, I describe the design of apparent feminism as a methodology and expand on its audiences and three major goals. Finally, I put those goals in conversation with each other and orient this new approach as a call to action for technical communicators.

A History of Feminist Technical Communication Research

This project begins from a foundation of work begun by feminist technical communicators. In particular, the 1990s saw a series of special issues on

feminisms by technical communication journals. The following authors are those who have most directly influenced this work:

- A 1991 special issue of *Journal of Business and Technical Communication* promoted a cultural turn in technical communication and provided foundations for work in feminisms and cultural studies (Brunner, 1991; Carrell, 1991; Flynn, Savage, Penti, Brown, & Watke, 1991; Lay, 1991).
- A 1992 special issue of *IEEE Transactions on Professional Communication* was devoted to the effects of gendered assumptions on understandings of rationality (Bernhardt, 1992; Bosley, 1992; Dell, 1992; Neeley, 1992; Rifkind & Harper, 1992; Sauer, 1992; Tebeaux & Lay, 1992).
- A 1994 issue of *Technical Communication Quarterly* studied social understandings of gender (Allen, 1994; Bosley, 1994; Gurak & Bayer, 1994; LaDuc & Goldrick-Jones, 1994; Ross, 1994; Sauer, 1994).
- A 1997 special issue of *Technical Communication Quarterly* recovered histories of women technical communicators and questioned the scarcity of such histories (Durack, 1997; E. A. Flynn, 1997; J. Flynn, 1997).

These special journal issues provide the most systematic, discipline-sponsored engagements with feminism by technical communicators, and their relative absence in the past decade and a half—as though feminisms in technical communication were a completed project—is worrisome. But my acknowledging of this waning interest is not meant to discredit the important work of those relatively few scholars who have continued to publish at the intersection of feminisms and technical communication in more solitary, self-sponsored fashion. These scholars (Bellwoar, 2012; Brady Aschauer, 1999; Brasseur, 1993, 2005; Boyer & Webb, 1992; Coletta, 1992; De Armas Ladd & Tangum, 1992; Dragga, 1993; Gregory, 2012; Haas, Tulley, & Blair, 2002; Hallenbeck, 2012; Koerber, 2002; Lay, 1993; Lay, Monk, & Rosenfelt, 2001; Lippincott, 2003; Sauer, 1993; Skinner, 2012; Tebeaux, 1993; Teston & Graham, 2012) have kept alive many threads of feminist technical communication inquiry.

Feminist technical communicators have often discussed the need for more wide-ranging feminist approaches in our field. In particular, feminist technical communicators have

- persisted in doing important feminist work even in the absence of discipline- and journal-sponsored forums
- embraced a plurality of feminisms and described myriad feminist methodologies and methods (Boyer & Webb, 1992; De Armas Ladd & Tangum, 1992)
- worked within and across gender studies, cultural studies, and social justice agendas (Brunner, 1991; Carrell, 1991; Flynn et al., 1991; Lay, 1991, 1993)
- conducted historiographical research and engaged in scholarly conversations about the importance of that research (Brasseur, 1993, 2005; Durack, 1997; E. A. Flynn, 1997; J. Flynn, 1997; Hallenbeck, 2012; Lippincott, 2003; Skinner, 2012; Tebeaux, 1993)
- provided critical perspectives on technologies, sciences, terminologies, and social conventions that hide value systems in which misogyny is supported, valued, and reproduced (Bernhardt, 1992; Bosley, 1992; Brady Aschauer, 1999; Colletta, 1992; Dell, 1992; Haas et al., 2002; Lay, 1993; Neeley, 1992; Rifkind & Harper, 1992; Sauer, 1992; Tebeaux & Lay, 1992)
- engaged in interdisciplinary scholarship and activism (Bellwoar, 2012; Gregory, 2012; Koerber, 2002; Teston & Graham, 2012)
- paid attention to the importance of social factors and intersectionality in terms of oppressions, theories, methodologies, practices, and more (Allen, 1994; Bosley, 1994; Dragga, 1993; Gurak & Bayer, 1994; LaDuc & Goldrick-Jones, 1994; Ross, 1994; Sauer, 1994)
- intervened in problematic actions (including rhetorics) that exist in and between public spheres, private lives, disciplinary venues, and pedagogical spaces (Lay et al., 2001; Sauer, 1993)

Technical communicators should listen to and emulate this important work, and they also should be aware—and troubled—that this work represents a minority population and a diminishing disciplinary trend. Apparent feminism can help remedy this.

Apparent Feminism as an Interdisciplinary Methodology

Technical communicators have no choice but to be public intellectuals; knowing that our work will influence the public, then, we must go about it especially carefully. Bowdon (2004) recognized four major areas of responsibility, suggesting that as technical communicators, we should (a) make our work part of the public sphere, (b) recognize the public nature of our work as teachers, (c) work toward positive change by recognizing social justice exigencies, and (d) recognize the subjectivity of our own bodies and being (pp. 325–326). Apparent feminism addresses the public sphere and attends to social, ethical, and political issues; works toward positive change in the world; and recognizes the existence of embodiment and its effects on theory. Bowden also encouraged technical communicators “to tell the stories of these projects, to let our colleagues and students know about what’s going on in these sites, and to identify places that might be good targets for more work” (p. 339). As Hemmings (2011) suggested, we do not even need to tell new stories; rather, we need to tell familiar stories differently. Apparent feminists can take up this call to tell such stories and, thus, insert feminist apparency into the public sphere. The first step in doing so is to pay attention to activists operating in the public sphere.

Apparent feminism builds on a foundation of the feminist technical communication scholarship that I surveyed. Further, I draw directly on four scholar-activists—indigenous environmental activist Winona LaDuke, cultural theorist and activist bell hooks (also known as Gloria Watkins), anthropologist Francesca Bray, and queer theorist Judith “Jack” Halberstam—to assemble a methodology intended to help technical communicators attend to social, ethical, political, and practical needs. These scholars not only provide guidance for assembling an apparent feminist methodology, but they also demonstrate how to employ it.

LaDuke’s work spans several areas requiring further attention from technical communicators, including environmental research, ethnicity, and health rhetorics—all of which she connected to issues of gender. LaDuke provided a venue for valuing the voices and knowledges of indigenous communities. Her work with communities whose health and lifeways have been threatened by legislative policy related to superfund sites is especially relevant. In her book *All Our Relations*, LaDuke (1999) chronicled the Mothers’ Milk Project run by Mohawk environmental justice activist Katsi Cook, who “studied 50 new mothers over several years and documented a 200 percent greater concentration of PCBs in the breast milk of those mothers

who ate fish from the St. Lawrence River as opposed to the general population” (p. 19) as a result of General Motors using the area as a toxic waste dump. LaDuke shared Cook’s efforts to heal the polluted land, water, associated food sources, and thus bodies of Mohawk people, and she traced multiple genres of technical communication—from meeting with and presenting to the Environmental Protection Agency to facing down big industries, from conducting original scientific research to writing reports, and from engaging with mainstream media to focusing on work on community healing—that could make a difference to them. Such work is a model to help move technical communicators toward being accountable for interrogating and responding to the potential injustices encoded in government and corporate policies.

Academic activist hooks’s work is important for technical communicators to engage in theorizing visual rhetoric in relation to gender and ethnic studies. Although she is no stranger to rhetoric and composition, hooks self-identifies as a cultural critic and scholar of feminism, race, and social justice. Showing how the art world—a place where expression and entrance might seem to be more open—is dominated by white males and white-male interests, hooks (1995) then turned to the creative work of black artists such as photographer Carrie Mae Weems and painter Jean-Michel Basquiat to show how visual culture can be used for empowerment by addressing identity politics through art. By looking to these artists’ past work for many of her examples of liberatory practices in visual culture, hooks both engaged in apparent feminist work and highlighted the importance of historiographic efforts.

Anthropologist Bray (1997) pointed out how technical communication is used to construct lives, spaces, times, and disciplines in gendered and power-laden ways. She took up historiographic goals in her feminist history of Imperial China; in so doing, she demonstrated that historiographic theory, methodology, and practice provide another way to support marginalized or underrepresented populations. Bray recovered and reenvisioned women’s roles in domestic spaces, textile production, and reproductive technologies. Before doing so, she provided a framework for thinking about feminist historiography, articulating a systematic methodology for undertaking gender-based inquiry. Bray theorized gynotechnics, a methodology that involves recognizing “a technical system that produces ideas about women, and therefore about a gender system and about hierarchical relations in general” (p. 4).

Lastly, queer theorist Halberstam’s (2005) reimagining of time and space has profound implications for how we understand the production and

distribution of technical documents; this queer reimagining is necessary in order to make the limitations of gender more apparent. An example of technical communication constructing our lives is the signage for public bathrooms, which is almost exclusively produced based on the assumption of sexual dimorphism. Thus, nonnormatively sexed and gendered people are confronted with an uneasy choice when faced with public bathrooms and other public spaces that are constructed based on sex or gender. Halberstam further argued that technical documents such as marriage contracts reify normative perspectives about the timeline for and required events within a person's life. As technical documents restrict our understandings of how, where, and when we do things, this area of inquiry is another space for interrogating the purposes, goals, biases, and implications of technical communication as seen through the lenses of gender studies and feminisms.

Design and Goals of Apparent Feminism

The term *apparent feminism*, like the dynamic spirit of rhetoric, is always in flux; it can be understood in different ways given different contexts, and it encourages practitioners to reflexively understand that apparent feminism is only one possible understanding of any given situation. I chose this term because the word *apparent*

- signifies the need to make feminist issues in everyday life conspicuous.
- emphasizes the valuing of explicitly feminist perspectives on such issues. Calling attention to a site for intervention is not enough; we must also point to the value of feminism as a response.
- points to the lack of apparency of important terms and their definitions in particular rhetorical contexts. For example, because *efficiency* is such a valued term in technical communication, it too often goes undefined and unexamined.
- calls on the notion of presence without using ableist language. As Teston (2012) puts it, "presence is about more than being visible to the eye. Presence is about being visible to one's consciousness" (p. 205). That is, the term *apparent* not only draws on the idea of constant presence, but it also is an active term that avoids rendering nonseeing bodies as abnormal.
- responds to the uninformed ways in which feminism is often criticized. The notion of apparency, in its incarnation as denoting

something potentially false, calls subversive attention to knee-jerk attacks on feminism.

I ask users of this methodology to also consider multiple meanings of the term apparent in order to “marshal the knowledge necessary to” resist the ideology of the term as used in this context “while at the same time also speaking in, and from within” that context (Sandoval, 2000, p. 44). Apparent feminists can draw on Sandoval’s (2000) theory of oppositional consciousness as a “politically effective means for transforming dominant power relations” (p. 44) in their use of the term apparent to describe their feminism.

In part because of this flexibility, all technical communication scholars and practitioners can benefit from taking up an apparent feminist methodology. Our main goal as public intellectuals and technical communicators should always be to do good work in the world; in this case, the meaning of *good* is partly based on our audiences, readers, and users. Apparent feminism can help us think about the diversity of potential audiences, what productive or efficient work is, and how to do our work in socially just⁴ ways. Scholars and practitioners of technical communication can use apparent feminism to think beyond the usual or initial audiences for any given piece of communication, and it can remind us to have reflexive conversations about what constitutes good, productive, efficient (etc.) work. Further, apparent feminism’s flexibility invites both feminist and nonfeminist technical communicators to the table. A technical communication scholar need not self-identify⁵ as feminist in order to use this methodology; apparent feminism purposefully does not demand such an identification. Rather, it seeks to highlight the opportunities for productive coalitions among many kinds of technical communicators.

The following subsections elucidate the three major goals of apparent feminism: making more apparent the need for feminist interventions, hailing nonfeminists as allies, and demystifying the relationship between feminism and efficiency. These goals are interrelated, and I separate them here only to convey their unique attributes. I conclude with a reassembled iteration of these goals—showcasing the value of feminist apparenity—and a call for others to take up this methodology.

Making More Apparent the Need for Feminist Interventions

First, apparent feminism recognizes the urgent exigencies for feminist critiques of contemporary politics. Further, it recognizes the importance of

making a feminist philosophical perspective apparent in such critiques. My drive toward such apparent results from the range of responses I have encountered in talking to students, friends, family members, and colleagues about feminism. I have found that responses to feminism often are tied up in rhetoric about bias; that is, people seem to believe that feminism is a particularly biased perspective. This belief in feminist bias—and, by extension, an implied belief in objectivity—has left me wanting to explore the possibilities of rhetorical, reflexive feminist approaches to technical communication.

Consider, for example, Texas's 2012 amendment to the 2003 Woman's Right to Know Act. This amendment—under the guise of a “woman's right”—requires women to have a medically extraneous ultrasound procedure performed before being able to access abortion services. Feminist responses to this law have often been attacked as “biased” and “radical” although they are surely no more biased or radical than the legislation itself. The presumption of bias is not an issue limited to feminism; the field of rhetoric—and, by extension, technical communication—struggles with the notion of bias as it interfaces with perception; this struggle enhances the exigence for an apparent feminist methodology that can help point to the universality of bias. Consider, for instance, that the main criticism of Bitzer's (1968) classic “Rhetorical Situation” is his reliance on a realist or objectivist theoretical approach. Vatz (1968) argued that Bitzer's realist philosophy has “important and, I believe, unfortunate implications for rhetoric” (p. 154), which Vatz articulated as the difference between defining rhetoric as a creative act or as a simple observation. In other words, Vatz argued that Bitzer leaves out the important role of human perception and discursive interpretations of perception in the rhetorical situation. In reinvesting the rhetorical situation with human perception, Vatz reversed each of Bitzer's main conclusions, “For example: I would not say ‘rhetoric is situational,’ but situations are rhetorical; not ‘... exigence strongly invites utterance,’ but utterance strongly invites exigence” (p. 159). Indeed, when considering the urgent need for apparent feminism, we see that the situation is highly rhetorical and that particular kinds of utterances, texts, and rhetorical acts create public biases—or, we might say, crises—which in turn demand an apparent feminist response.

The urgency for this methodology arises from the fact that feminists who attempt to respond to attacks on female bodies that are perpetrated through technical documentation (as in the Texas act that I just cited) and technology (in this example, the ultrasound equipment) are often written off as hysterical or hostile—or altogether silenced. Many scholars whose work

qualifies as apparent feminism rebel against this silencing and simultaneously against the separation of embodiment and technological culture (Munster, 2006; Nakamura, 2008). Munster (2006) argued that digital histories “have limited the present and future possibilities for bodies in culture” (p. 9) and that, in response, we should create an alternative digital genealogy that takes “body, sensation, movement and conditions such as place and duration into account” (p. 3). Munster called for “a more expansive conception of materiality” that “can help us to draw intensive connections between the actions and affects of bodies and forces of digital code” (p. 85). As many scholars have noted, technologies and bodies are codependent and always acting upon each other (Bray, 1997; Frost & Haas, in press; Nakamura, 2008). Apparent feminism is concerned with the effects of technologies (e.g., those included in abortion, ultrasound, and medicine) on bodies and with who gets to decide when the two interact in particular ways.

Working toward feminist apparency and intervention can call attention to different understandings of such technological processes that shape cultural commonplaces. Apparent feminist projects might include calling attention to highly visible rhetorics—such as legal documents—that shape our ideologies. The cultural importance of these documents is already readily apparent, but such technical artifacts are not often considered to be sites of culture making. Apparent feminism seeks to recover understandings of such rhetorics as culturally saturated, and it seeks to question who stands to benefit from such culturally saturated spaces. To explain, pointing out that an ultrasound exam is a medically extraneous procedure in relation to abortion services is an example of how an apparent feminist might make more apparent the ideologies behind such abortion rhetorics.

This urgency for feminist intervention also exists in disciplinary contexts, which in turn affect public understandings. Feminist work in technical communication began with the recognition of gender as a social category, as shown by the 1991 issue of the *Journal of Business and Technical Communication* (“Gender and Professional Communication”) that focuses on gender as part of a cultural turn. The 1994 issue of *Technical Communication Quarterly* then focuses on women’s contributions to technical communication, a technique that has sometimes been critiqued as the add-women-and-stir approach. Between 1994 and a historiographical push in 1997, some feminist technical communicators recognized that “stirring” women into the field was entirely reshaping the content of the field (Durack, 1997). These knowledges and histories have expanded the scope and expertise of the field and made more apparent how insidious technical communication can be in the construction of everyday life for all people, including

but not limited to women. The realization that feminist influences can produce new and robust sets of perspectives on disciplinary content areas should inspire more technical communication scholars to take up feminist perspectives in their work.

In review, apparent feminism is a methodological approach that can work within the fields of technical communication by emphasizing the importance of making feminisms explicit. It responds to the suggestion of a postfeminist world by reasserting the relevance of and need for feminist perspectives in contemporary social politics. Apparent feminism supports

- ways of pointing out and resisting oppressive technical communication and rhetoric, particularly when such oppressions are based on sex and gender
- our understandings of objects, processes, technologies, and ideas often considered to be neutral or objective as being culturally saturated
- persuasive responses to detractors of feminism
- discussions about identity politics and the problems of associating oneself with the term feminism

To be sure, several of these concerns also bear on the other interrelated goals of apparent feminism. I will make those connections more apparent as follows.

Hailing Nonfeminists as Allies

The recognition of allies⁶ is an important rhetorical strategy for apparent feminism. That is, apparent feminist technical communicators are interested in building coalitions with those who might appear to be feminist in their activism or ideological perspectives but do not embrace that label. As an example, an apparent feminist scholar of technical communication and a nonfeminist lawyer interested in working to overturn unjust regulations (e.g., the Texas Woman's Right to Know Act) might form a symbiotic partnership to great result. This advocacy of coalition performs several functions. First, it creates more spaces for conversations about the value and challenges of feminist identification. Second, it provides an alternative to the exhausting, decades-old notion that feminists themselves must bear an increased ethical burden to demystify and fight against gender inequities.

This invitation to allies comes with the necessity of giving up some measure of control in order to gain new, interdisciplinary, diverse approaches

to technical communication. In this way, apparent feminism encourages increased inclusivity and diversity in our understandings of and conversations about gendered systems. Apparent feminism requires not just that feminists take a stand—as they often have done—but that they allow spaces for those who do not self-identify as feminists to enter the conversation. It allows for a person to do feminist work, and even to recognize it as such if they wish, without necessarily self-identifying as a feminist. In other words, apparent feminism recognizes that it is, itself, a methodology with particular investments (or biases) and that other (equally biased and equally legitimate) methodologies might be complementary. For instance, apparent feminism lends itself to a variety of cultural studies approaches that have been taken on by technical communication scholars. It can contribute to and dialogue with work such as that by Grabill (2007) and Haas, Tulley, and Blair (2002), for example. Apparent feminism, therefore, can sponsor bridges between a wide variety of both interdisciplinary and technical communication scholar-practitioners, including those invested in critical race theory, gender theory, postcolonial and decolonial theory, cultural theory, and more.

Marking work that complements feminist goals is a historical as well as a contemporary project. That is, apparent feminism might help us find allies whose work has already been done. This notion of apparency after the fact is particularly important because it can help to recover feminist works that were not previously recognized as such. For example, although some of the works I discussed here are not apparently feminist, I was able to use them in ways that are explicitly feminist without violating the spirit of their messages; indeed, I hope that my work here—and my recognition of the apparent feminism of other works—will further the projects of scholars like Bray, Halberstam, hooks, and LaDuke.

Finally, because apparent feminism is a methodology based on technical communication, part of its purpose is to value the expertise of all of our potential allies. To explain, the term *technical* refers to the existence of a specific, specialized audience. While specialization is potentially exclusionary, apparent feminism makes clear that all individuals have their own diverse technical expertise. Technical communication practitioners are well prepared to recognize, honor, and work in concert with these diverse skill sets. We are a discipline quite used to working with subject-matter experts. How we construct the social frameworks that recognize expertise—how we invite peers, including nonfeminist allies, to the conversation—is what really matters.

Demystifying the Relationship Between Feminism and Efficiency

Apparent feminism resists refusals to examine our disciplinary terms, instead requiring that we interrogate the invisible underpinnings of these terms to make their values more apparent. At this moment, one of the most important terms requiring apparent feminist attention is *efficiency*. A particular understanding of the term efficiency has become quite naturalized for technical communicators; thus, contextual definitions of efficiency too often go unarticulated. Apparent feminism points to those unarticulated parts. Specifically, apparent feminism responds to the stifling of cultural diversity in the name of efficiency, which is a term that—contrary to some understandings of it—relies on the existence of diversity for its value (for a detailed critique of modern usages of the term diversity, see Ahmed, 2012). To explain, efficiency is commonly understood as the balancing point at which we achieve the best result while expending the least amount of energy. But technical communication as a discipline is currently most focused on the latter part of that definition. Apparent feminist technical communicators must rearticulate efficiency as focused primarily on audiences as a component of best results—and must draw attention to which audiences we focus on.

In advocating this new focus, I also recognize that the balance between these two criteria for determining efficiency is contextual. I believe that technical communicators, in general, need to shift our focus from energy expended to results produced because of troubling patterns within disciplinary rhetorics. But apparent feminists must always keep in mind that the best balance in order to achieve ethical, effective, socially just technical communication will be different depending on the rhetorical situation.

Apparent feminism seeks to make the symbiotic relationship between feminism, diversity, and efficiency more apparent. I begin this article by drawing a connection between diversity and feminism. As suggested by much of the literature I have cited thus far, feminists are concerned with people other than just those who self-identify as women (Butler, 1990; Evans, 2012). Social justice—which focuses on justice for the wider community—is the ultimate goal of apparent feminism, so apparent feminists are interested in being inclusive of people marginalized by hegemonic understandings of ethnicity, class, and ability in technical communication theory and practice. In essence, when we invoke the term efficiency, we must also make apparent the contextual implications for ethics. For example, Dragga and Voss (2001) discussed a statistician who, “prizing efficiency and ignoring ethics,” insisted on using only scientific data

(p. 267). This phrasing demonstrates an understanding of efficiency as distinct from ethics, an understanding that I believe is too common among technical communicators and that we have an obligation to disrupt.

The notion of efficiency relies on the existence of diversity⁷ for its value; apparent feminism argues that being inclusive of cultural diversity contributes to the potential for efficiency. This reasoning might initially seem counterintuitive to some technical communicators who might argue that a traditional style exists and that including more audiences means doing more work and would therefore contribute to inefficiency. But because technical communication is consumed and produced by culturally diverse audiences, and because technical communicators cannot always predict the rhetorical velocity (Ridolfo & DeVoss, 2009) of their texts, producing texts that can be usable and useful to as many potential audience members as possible in a given context is necessary in our increasingly globalized and digitized discipline and world (Nakamura, 2008). Remembering that efficiency is defined as the balancing point at which we achieve the best result from the least amount of energy, we must recognize that this increased audience represents a significantly greater result. Ultimately, then, apparent feminist practices have the potential to produce more efficient work—if we operate under this reimagined version of the term efficiency. Consider Jones's (2012) heartbreaking account of her interaction with the Texas Woman's Right to Know Act. While a certain percentage of the population might consider the law to be good or productive, Jones certainly is not a member of that group. Taking into account her positionality might have produced more socially just—for a wider potential audience—regulatory rhetoric.

Current understandings of the term efficiency in technical communication constrain the goals of apparent feminism, and this constraint is of utmost importance because the term efficiency has such value to the discipline of technical communication. That is, with such value placed on efficiency, adhering to whatever understanding exists for that term in a particular cultural context becomes of utmost importance because anyone who can be labeled inefficient is a threat to the status quo. Efficiency can easily become so embedded as a cultural value that it is no longer explicitly discussed—the shifting balance of energy expended versus goodness done is not articulated—and it is then a small step to using efficiency to justify racism, sexism, ableism, and other evils. McRuer (2006) pointed out that the work of efficiency experts “played a large part in the emergence of the identity of the able-bodied worker” (p. 88). In determining what was efficient, these experts had to construct ideas about which bodies could work most effectively, therefore privileging some bodies over others.

We can see new strains of this ethic of efficiency in many modern conversations; one such conversation that is particularly important for technical communicators is about digital education and the accessibility of technology. DePew, Fishman, Romberger, and Ruetenik (2006) suggested that competing ideologies of efficiency in digital education require our attention and that “the privileging of efficiency over pedagogical principles of dialogism, collaboration, and an emphasis on process must be resisted” (p. 64). In a similar vein, Eubanks (2011) warned that social justice advocates who emphasize technology accessibility without accompanying rhetorical training “as the route to greater prosperity and equality for all Americans” are engaging in “a familiar but dangerously underexamined species of magical thinking” (p. xv). In other words, the common belief that more technology is an equalizer and a road to greater efficiency for large audiences leaves out a lot of ethical complexities.

Because a particular understanding of the term efficiency has become so naturalized for technical communicators, parts of its definition often go unarticulated. Apparent feminism addresses this by making apparent those unarticulated parts. To illustrate, one recent definition of efficiency is “the rate at which users can successfully complete a task after they have learned the system” (Simmons & Zoetewey, 2012, p. 266). In this case, efficiency is defined as being almost entirely about time or energy spent. Apparent feminists point out that the aforementioned definition could be improved upon by talking about the quality of the task completed. Apparent feminists might revise this definition to focus on the importance of multiple identities of users. For example, Simmons and Zoetewey ultimately criticized the traditional notion that engaging the multiple identities of a single user is a drain on efficiency. They made apparent that they privilege these diverse identities and the qualities they bring to the situation, thereby helping to dismantle the efficiency–diversity dissonance.

In shifting the focus of efficiency away from energy and toward people, apparent feminist technical communicators must constantly ask themselves if their work is efficient within multiple long-term and short-term frames of reference. For example, is a particular action efficient both in terms of serving their employer and in terms of serving the interests of social justice? Ornatowski’s (1992) approach is one that I appropriate as apparent feminist work because he made it apparent that the particular actors involved in a rhetorical situation determine the way that efficiency is enacted. Ornatowski pointed out that a technical communicator is always held responsible for two contradictory goals: She is supposed to be objective and yet serve the interests of her employer.

Using textbooks as the (admittedly limited) basis of his critique, Ornato-wski suggested that efficiency is “understood in terms of usefulness to employers” (p. 93) and that technical communication that does not serve the employer is deemed inefficient. He resolved this contradiction with the argument that efficiency is always political (p. 100). For apparent feminists, understanding efficiency as political encourages caution—but not necessarily resistance.

Apparent feminism suggests that we can retain efficiency as a primary guidepost for determining the value of technical communication as long as we are careful in articulating our understandings of what efficiency means. Katz’s (1992) work with the term *expediency* provides an example of technical communication’s use of efficiency and the ways in which it moves through our rhetoric without requiring us to critically analyze its use. Katz—who was being especially careful with his terms—repeatedly invoked efficiency, but the term is so familiar to his technical communication audience that he did not define it. To provide some context, Katz criticized expediency as a criterion for determining effective technical communication by beginning with the example of a Nazi memo that is technically effective but ethically repugnant. In the following quotations from Katz’s article, the emphases on usages of efficiency rhetoric are mine:

- “The writer shows no concern that the purpose of his memo is the modification of vehicles not only to improve *efficiency*, but also to exterminate people” (p. 257).
- “The whole society organized into a death machine for the *efficient* extirpation of millions, lauded by the Nazis as a hallmark of organization, elegance, *efficiency*, speed, all of which became ends in themselves for those planning and those executing the procedures” (p. 265).
- “Propaganda thus served to create the technological ethos of Nazi consciousness and culture: rationality, *efficiency*, speed, productivity, power” (p. 268).

In all these instances, Katz shows the term *efficiency* being used to emphasize the minimization of energy expended rather than the maximization of positive effects on human lives (which, in this case, would certainly be a negative value). Apparent feminism suggests that efficiency can be used as an ethical end, but only if we understand efficiency as being focused primarily on effects on human lives and secondarily on speed and energy.

The rearticulation of efficiency as audience focused is important because apparent feminism suggests that the disciplinary domination of male perspectives in technical communication—a domination that has been continuously reproduced in the name of efficiency—has limited the scope of what technical communication can and should do. When we revise our understandings of audiences as diverse, rather than just male, the nature of efficiency changes. This point is especially important in the discipline of technical communication because it is so heavily male dominated (Allen, 1994; Bosley, 1994; Flynn et al., 1991; Rauch, 2012; Ross, 1994; Royal, 2005; Thompson & Overman Smith, 2006⁸). Understanding efficiency as something that benefits those already in power, something that reinforces the status quo, something more focused on energy expended than on people affected, prevents us from doing good, ethical, socially just work. But understanding efficiency as something that focuses on both energy expended and people affected, something that places primary importance on the human rights of stakeholders, might lead us toward altogether different practices.

This efficiency as imagined from a feminist perspective is “humanistic, life-oriented, non-exploitative” (Rothschild, 1981, p. 66). If we—apparent feminist technical communicators—are truly interested in doing efficient work, we must embrace diversity in order to hail larger audiences. Thus, apparent feminists work to make apparent the ways that efficiency actually relies on other concepts—like feminism as it supports diversity—for its value.

Reassembling a Theory of Feminist Apparency

While I have articulated this theory of apparent feminism as a sort of three-pronged approach, it is important to understand that these three goals are interrelated, and each of these goals is reliant on the others. In the following list, I demonstrate these interrelationships by specifically articulating one way in which each goal relies on the other two:

- The goal of making more apparent to as many audiences as possible the need for feminist interventions depends on
 - having allies to help us widen our reach and
 - understanding apparent feminism as an efficient approach
- The goal of hailing nonfeminists as allies depends on
 - making our feminism apparent so that allies might recognize us and
 - believing that attracting allies is an efficient approach

- The goal of demystifying the relationship between feminism and efficiency depends on
 - making apparent our reimagining of the term *efficiency* and of technical communication as a discipline and
 - having allies who can participate in this reimagining so that it has effects in social, ethical, political, and practical domains

The preceding list makes clear how each goal of this methodology relies on the other two goals. Still, though, this is not an exhaustive list of the ways that these features interrelate but rather a sketch intended to show some of the ways that each goal depends on the others.

I call on technical communicators to take up this methodology in order to point out and intervene in systemic oppression. The examples that I have given here—most prominently, the Texas Woman’s Right to Know Act but also similar laws passed by Arizona and Virginia—are just a small sample of exigencies that bear specifically on reproductive justice (Arizona Women’s Health and Safety Act, 2012; SB 484, 2012; Woman’s Right to Know Act, 2012).⁹ Apparent feminism can be leveraged to address a wide range of social injustices in a wide range of arenas all bearing on technical communication, from government regulations to social policy to digital rhetorics to professional gatekeeping to street harassment and more.

Apparent feminism is an urgently needed methodology in technical communication at this kairotic moment precisely because of the knee-jerk response that makes feminism unpersuasive to some audiences; conversations about feminism, particularly in technical realms, too often result in it being vilified or dismissed as biased. It is more important than ever for feminist work to be marked as such in the face of allegations of a postfeminist world, particularly in male-dominated disciplines such as technical communication. Feminist technical communicators “must continue to seek out ways of thinking that will help make operations of power and hegemony” more apparent (LaDuc & Goldrick-Jones, 1994, p. 247). Ultimately, I hope that apparent feminism can provide a temporary, permeable, and flexible approach to the many current situations facing technical communicators that are in need of feminist intervention.

Acknowledgments

I am deeply indebted to Angela Haas, Gerald Savage, and Julie Jung for helping to shape this article in its earliest versions. In addition, many thanks to Kellie Sharp-

Hoskins, Katrina Dunbar, Gretchen Frank, Michelle Eble, Jamie Henthorn, Kate Gramlich Roubos, Kimberly Hall, and Veronika Novoselova for their helpful feedback and suggestions.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Notes

1. Visible rhetoric is a subdiscipline of rhetoric that focuses on the persuasive use of nonalphabetic modes of communication (e.g., the appropriation and captioning of ultrasound images to persuade pregnant people to carry pregnancies to term).
2. The term *people* is used purposefully here; while the most common sites of fetal ultrasound are the bodies of people who identify as women, several cases of pregnant men mean that more inclusive terminology is required. Further, the partners of pregnant people are also victims of this legislation. I use the term *people* to be inclusive of different groups and also to point out that feminisms work in service of more than just the group that self-identifies as women.
3. While the word *apparent* obviously signifies the need to make feminist issues in everyday life conspicuous, the notion of apparency in its incarnation as denoting something potentially false calls subversive attention to the uninformed ways in which feminism is often attacked.
4. The term *social justice* refers to an obligation to widen our perspective when thinking about fairness in social situations. The term *social* indicates recognition of more than a single (kind of) subject, refocusing our energy on broader, more inclusive and diverse applications of our existing understanding of the principle of justice.
5. Self-identification is a complex subject. Suffice it to say that identification, like apparent feminism, is always in flux (see Ratcliffe, 2005).
6. In taking up the term *allies*, I draw on a history of gay, lesbian, bisexual, transgender, transsexual, and queer activism. The term has also been used by indigenous activists and social justice-oriented groups.
7. *Diversity*, like feminism, is a term laden with many possible connotations. Further, much like efficiency, it is a term that is sometimes invoked symbolically and without critical analysis (Ahmed, 2012). I use diversity here to talk about the

importance of considering cultural difference in technical audiences. While I focus here on gender-based and sex-based differences, this cultural diversity could (and should) also include ethnic, national, religious, philosophical, and political diversity—among other meanings of diversity that my own cultural positioning makes unapparent at this juncture.

8. Some of these sources are dated, so they are articulating perspectives on the discipline as it looked at another point in time. I include these sources, as well as more current ones, to show that even as the field changes over time, some patterns unfortunately seem to be rather stable.
9. Indeed, I have only mentioned 3 of the 24 states that have passed similar legislation (Frost, 2013).

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